

Checkmate is about every escape

Foundations

THE IDEA

Checkmate requires the king to be in check with no legal way to remove the attack. A dramatic checking move is insufficient if the defender can capture the checker, block, or escape. Test those possibilities explicitly.

WORKED EXAMPLE

A queen may stand next to the king and give check, yet be capturable if unsupported. The same queen placement becomes mate when a friendly piece protects her and all king escapes are covered or blocked.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

What are the three tests after a candidate mating check?

ANSWER AND REASONING

Can the king move safely, can the checker be captured, and can the attack be blocked? If every legal answer fails, it is mate. For a knight check, the block test is unnecessary.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

Prove mate by exhausting defenses.